

LEFT, RIGHT and MID in Excel

1. What are LEFT, RIGHT and MID?

LEFT, RIGHT, and MID extract a set number of characters from text. LEFT takes them from the start, RIGHT takes them from the end, and MID takes them from any position in the middle. They solve the problem of codes and IDs that combine several pieces of information in one cell, such as a prefix, a year, and a number. A Data Analyst uses them to split these codes into separate columns.

2. Syntax

Function	Syntax	Arguments
LEFT	=LEFT(text, [num_chars])	text is required. num_chars is optional. The default is 1.
RIGHT	=RIGHT(text, [num_chars])	text is required. num_chars is optional. The default is 1.
MID	=MID(text, start_num, num_chars)	text, start_num, and num_chars are all required.

text is a cell reference or text in quotes. num_chars is how many characters to return. start_num is the position of the first character to take, where the first character in the text is position 1. Spaces count as characters.

3. Simple Example

Cell A2 contains the word Bangladesh. Each letter has a position:

Letter	B	a	n	g	i	a	d	e	s	h
Position	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10

Formula	Result
=LEFT(A2, 3)	Ban
=RIGHT(A2, 3)	esh
=MID(A2, 4, 3)	gla

LEFT takes the first 3 characters. RIGHT takes the last 3. MID starts at position 4 (g) and takes 3 characters.

4. Another Example

Split employee IDs into a prefix, a year, and a number:

	A	B	C	D
1	Employee ID	Prefix	Year	No.
2	EMP-2026-105	EMP	2026	105
3	EMP-2025-212	EMP	2025	212
4	EMP-2026-087	EMP	2026	087

Formulas in row 2, copied down: B2 =LEFT(A2, 3), C2 =MID(A2, 5, 4), D2 =RIGHT(A2, 3)

In EMP-2026-105, the year starts at position 5 and is 4 characters long. The results are text, so the leading zero in "087" is kept.

5. When to Use It

- Extract prefixes or country codes from the start of IDs (LEFT)
- Extract the last digits of an ID, or a postal code from the end (RIGHT)
- Extract a year, department code, or other part from the middle of a code (MID)
- Split fixed-format codes into separate columns
- Extract a file extension or an area code that always has the same length

6. Important Things to Remember

- LEFT starts at the first character, RIGHT starts at the last character, and MID starts at any position you choose.
- num_chars is optional in LEFT and RIGHT (default 1), but MID needs all three arguments. MID has no default.
- The results are text, even when they look like numbers, such as "105" or "087". Use VALUE() to convert them to numbers.
- If num_chars is longer than the text, you get the whole text. In MID, a start_num beyond the end gives an empty result.
- A start_num below 1 or a negative num_chars gives #VALUE!.
- These functions work best when every code has the same length and layout.

7. Common Mistakes

Mistake: Leaving out arguments in MID, such as =MID(A2), which gives an error. **Fix:** Always give start_num and num_chars: =MID(A2, 5, 4).

Mistake: Counting positions wrongly, for example forgetting that the first character is position 1, or skipping spaces and hyphens. **Fix:** Write out the characters with their positions, as in the Bangladesh example.

Mistake: Adding up the extracted numbers and getting 0, because they are text. **Fix:** Convert them with VALUE(RIGHT(A2, 3)).

Mistake: Using a fixed number of characters on text of different lengths, so words are cut off. **Fix:** Find the position first with FIND, as in the tip below.

8. Data Analyst Tip

When the pieces have different lengths, let Excel find the position for you. For example, =LEFT(A2, FIND("-", A2) - 1) returns everything before the first hyphen, whatever its length. For EMP-2026-105 it returns EMP.